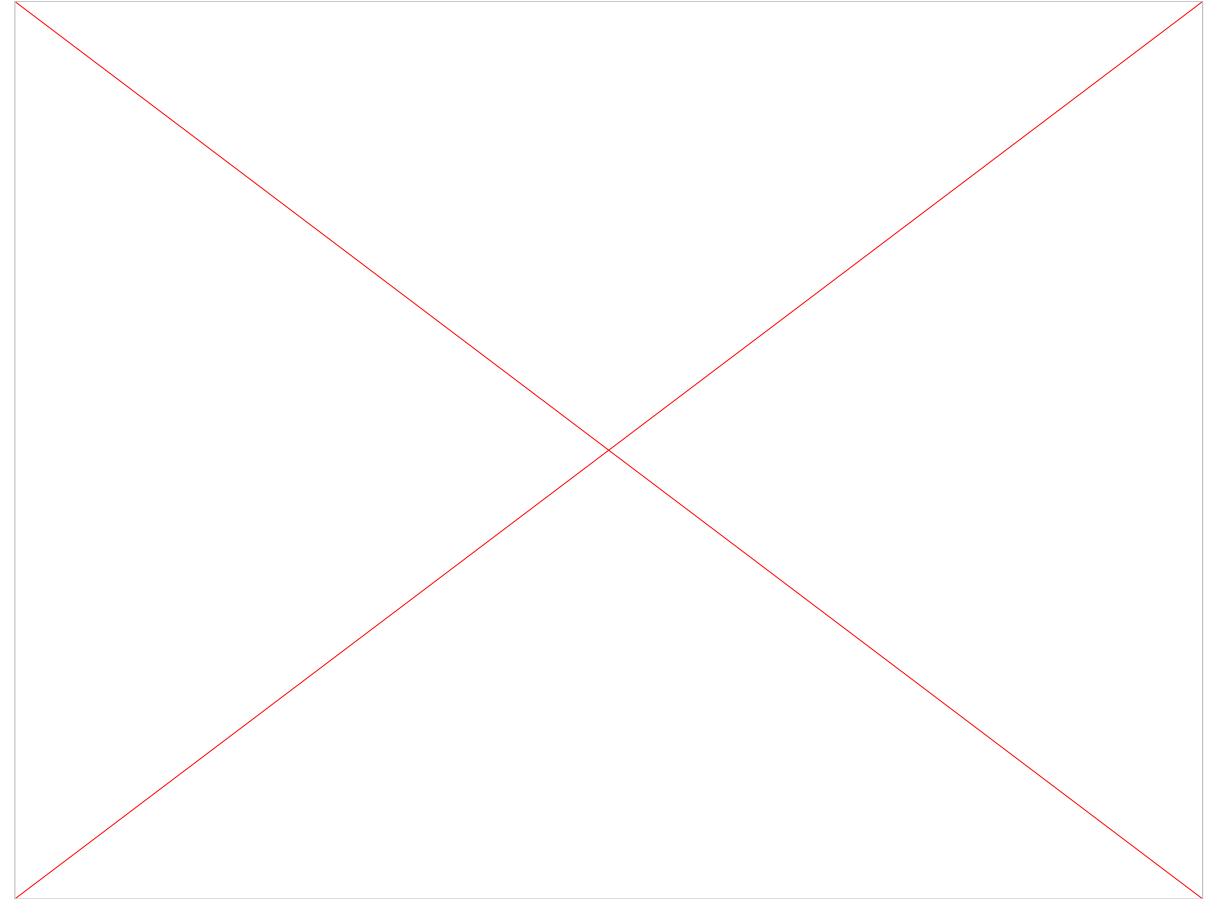


A Cross-Cultural Study of Aesop's Fables and Sukumar Ray's "Abol Tabol"

ENG 110: Literature for Life



About Aesop: <https://iep.utm.edu/aesop/#H2>
<https://youtu.be/rjsQwRoi0yw?si=XhQwbU0cjSrwiKX>
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- Phaedruss—the main channel by which Latin readers in antiquity and even the Middle Ages knew Aesopic fables—offers up his own explanation of fable in the prologue to his third book of fable in verse. He says, “Now I will explain briefly why the type of thing called fable was invented. The slave, being liable to punishment for any offense, since he dared not say outright what he wished to say, projected his personal sentiments into fable and alluded censure under the guise of jesting with made-up stories” (Phaedrus 3)

Gayatri Spivak in “Can the Subaltern Speak?”

“No perspective critical of imperialism can turn the other into a self, because the project of imperialism has always already historically refracted what might have been the other into a domesticated other that consolidates the imperialist self” (253)

Jyotirmoy Sasmal in “Beyond Whimsy, *Abol Tabol* And The SocioPolitical Context Of Colonial India: A Study Of Selected Limericks” asserts that

“The snake charmer ('Baburam') can be identified as Farrukhsiyar, the 10th Mughal Empire, and the narrator as British colonialists; “The Farrukhsiyar’s Farman (April 1717) gave the Company the right to purchase 38 villages around Sutanuti, Gobindapur and Kolikata and collect taxes directly from the provinces and instilled rulers who would suit the interest of the Company.” (3)

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- The real power is in being clever
- Sukumar Ray's text resonates to the readers in a manner that illustrates that the unequal power balance almost always benefits the dominant class.
- Colonial hybridity (*Bhadra Shomaaj*) is not an idealistic mix of culture rather it is another colonial narrative.

- Human beings, because of their unique capability of reason, have the opportunity to live differently than animals. In fact, rather than providing lessons on how to survive in a brutal, predatory world, the fables can point towards a means for escaping that world. They can actually point towards democracy, equality, and justice rather than hierarchy, power, and exploitation.
- Limitations of animals and their discourses are much more violent
- Aristotle claims that it is not correct from a biological point of view to divide animals into the categories of "tame" and "wild" as some before him have done: "For in a manner of speaking everything that is tame is also wild, e.g. human beings, horses, cattle" ^

- Born wild and free? The attempts of reasoning and beyond

Inquire from Fables and Nonsensical Poems

- How do the authors represent the dominant class of the society?
- Do the fables resonate in the current socio-political setting?
- Why are “talking animals”/ “hybrid animals” an absurd, yet effective method of illustrating a didactic point of view?
- Aristotle mentions “If you do not have any evidence to support your point, a fable can be just as helpful”. (How?)
- How do the *Bhadra Shomaaj* /modern corporation shadow an imperial system in a society? Elaborate